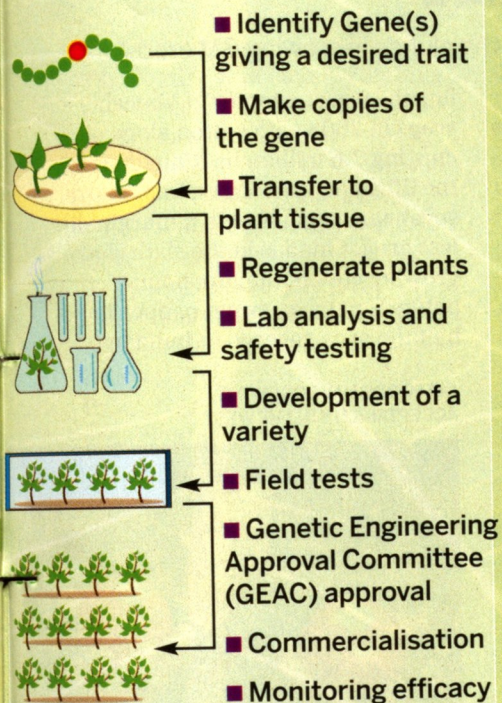


Stages in the GM Ladder



The Bt Cotton Revolution



In 2002, the Government permitted the commercial cultivation of Bt cotton. Despite widespread criticism, it has been an unqualified success.

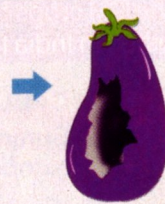
Transgenic cotton is grown in 90 per cent of the cotton-growing areas in the country, increasing yields by as much as 50 per cent in certain regions.

duction of GM foods. They charge the GEAC with relying much too heavily on the trials and findings of Mahyco, without adequate independent testing and verification. "It is unacceptable and a shame that the regulator in the country has put the interests of corporations over the interests of ordinary citizens," says Kavitha Kuruganti of the Kheti Virasat Mission. Greenpeace, the global environmental activist group, says that it is shocking that the GEAC has mindlessly gone ahead and approved Bt brinjal even when informed scientists and citizens of the country raised se-

Bt Brinjal: Seeds of Debate



In India, brinjal yields have been seriously affected by the pesticide-resistant stem and fruit borer. The GM brinjal has a gene that encodes a protein with insecticidal properties.



Damaged Shoot



An ordinary brinjal plant succumbs to the borer (left), while Bt brinjal remains unaffected.



Destroyed Fruit



A regular brinjal fruit (left) is devastated by the borer, while Bt brinjal shows no ill-effects.



The Claim

- The Government says all studies put on website and clearance took nine years
- Extensive trials done by public sector laboratories, like ICAR, cleared Bt Brinjal
- Expert committee cleared all trials and was satisfied with governmental controls

The Refutation

- NGOs charge lack of transparency and undue haste in GEAC clearance for Bt brinjal
- GEAC poorly equipped to address bio-safety concerns and favours industry lobby
- No independent evaluation mechanism and Government depends on the multinational

Graphics by PRASHANT CHAUDHARY/www.indiatodayimages.com

rious concerns on the nature of the safety studies. "The GEAC is hand-in-glove with the industry lobby and is not on the side of the public. It has failed the country," says Rajesh Krishnan, campaigner (sustainable agriculture) at Greenpeace.

The concerns and controversy spring from the initial failure of the GEAC over addressing issues of transparency, making public the nature and details of the trials carried out, the bio-safety of the products—there are four varieties of brinjals on the table for approval—and the conflicting interests of the experts in the com-

mittee reviewing the studies. Denying that they have held back information, Ranjini Warriar, member secretary, GEAC, says: "We have put out everything that the public and experts want to know about the entire process of granting approval for Bt brinjal on our website. We have nothing to hide." Sajiv Anand, director, All India Crop Biotechnology Association, concurs and says, "The GEAC has looked at every possible bio-safety issue before clearing the crop. It is unlikely that Bt brinjal will not get approval from the Government."

Other opponents raise larger is-